frontier was not a source of major threat until the age of Western imperialism. There is no record of any military offensive launched against China from the maritime space on its eastern flank. Chinese junks or trading vessels were a common sight in the ports of South-East Asia, the Indian subcontinent, the Gulf and even East Africa since at least the Tang dynasty (618–907 CE). But the importance attached to China as a front-ranking naval power is a more contemporary articulation. Nevertheless, the various kingdoms in East Asia, South-East Asia and beyond, which maintained long-standing trading relationships with China, were also slotted into the Chinese world view of itself as the civilized centre with concentric zones of diminishing civilizational status.

The tributary system became a framework within which this hierarchical order was perceived, even though the reality may have been different. For example, Japan was never brought under Chinese political influence even though it borrowed heavily from Chinese culture. There were flourishing and militarily powerful kingdoms in South-East Asia which never acknowledged even a notional Chinese overlordship. These included the Majapahit (1293–1527) and Srivijaya (650–c. 1275 CE) kingdoms in Indonesia, and the Chola kingdom (c. 300 BCE –1279 CE) in India.

There was a brief interlude during the Ming dynasty (1368–1644), when the Chinese emperor commissioned a series of long-range voyages into the Indian Ocean under the admiralship of a remarkable eunuch and high official belonging to the Muslim faith, Zheng He. He undertook a series of seven voyages from 1403 CE to 1421 CE , with an impressive fleet of several tens of large ‘treasure ships’, exploring and reporting to the emperor on distant lands and kingdoms. But this impressive display of the naval power and grandeur of the Chinese empire proved to be a flash in the pan. A new Ming emperor, Hong Xi (1424–25 CE), not only banned any further naval expeditions but also stopped the building of large ocean-going vessels. The detailed maritime charts and maps made during Zheng He’s remarkable voyages were mostly destroyed. China turned its back on the maritime world for the next several centuries.

The history of China and of the Asian world may have been very different